P77 [Part 1] Real English Vocabulary Quiz for Room 101 [LEP#980]

Hello premium listeners,

How are you doing? Yes, it is new premium episode time.

You'll see this one is called Real English Vocabulary Quiz for Room 101.

This is a vocabulary quiz based on expressions which you will hear in the next free episode of this podcast - episode 980, arriving on Monday. That episode is called Room 101 with Charlie Baxter.

Consider this to be a sort of vocabulary preview for that episode.

You can listen to this, and then you can spot the vocabulary when you listen to episode 980. It also works the other way around of course, if you end up listening to episode 980 first, that is fine.

This is all part of my method of presenting English authentically and in context and helping you notice, pick up and use new vocabulary.

Part of that is being aware of gaps in your own English and showing you how you can fill those gaps with exactly the sorts of English phrases that native speakers use completely naturally. I want to help you learn to speak like me, as is always the aim in my premium episodes.

In Monday's episode (LEP980) you will be able to enjoy a very funny conversation with Charlie Baxter. I am confident enough to say that it is a funny conversation. The topics and stories are relatable, and in one case a bit disgusting (which I hope you're ok with), and there are jokes and amusing anecdotes all the way through. It was fun to record and I did not need to edit a single thing.

I have picked out about 30 expressions that Charlie and I used while talking - about 30 expressions that came up naturally in our conversation: idioms, collocations, informal expressions and bits of British humour. Real British English that you might not get in traditional coursebook materials.

The first part of this will be a quiz which is interactive. You have to guess the words I am talking about. We've done this before so you should know the format. This seems to be a popular way to present language like this in premium episodes, but there will also some detailed explanations too, after the quiz, when I will break down each expression, explain what it means, show you how it's

used, give extra examples, and talk about when it's appropriate to use them.

You could do all that research yourself, but by doing it for you I will basically save you a lot of time and effort, and you can rest assured that I am a professional with a particular set of skills so you're in safe hands.

A slight content warning: As I alluded to earlier, some of the vocabulary comes from a rather ridiculous story from Charlie involving a public toilet, and a series of unfortunate events relating to his underpants. That is slightly disgusting perhaps and some of the language is a bit rude, including one swear word - The "S word" - I think you can handle it - not literally.

The expressions I have picked are extremely useful for many everyday situations and conversations: complaining about things, describing problems, telling stories, or reacting to funny situations. The language is emphatic, specific and 100% worth learning if you want to speak English naturally and not like a robot.

So let's get started.

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1. **Vocab quiz + answers**
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First, the vocabulary quiz. I did most of this with my wife yesterday by the way, and she absolutely loved it and said it's her favourite kind of exercise that I do. I hope you like it too.

• Vocabulary Quiz

Can you identify the bits of English vocabulary I am talking about here? Let's do this like a game. I'll do it in 3 rounds, with a little break between each round, when you can walk around the block, or splash some water on your face.

All the answers are given below this quiz.

ROUND 1

Question 1

What expression means to be **naturally interested in doing something** or **likely to behave in a particular way because of your personality or preferences**?

Imagine you are talking to a person about their personality, and saying that you think they are not normally a pessimistic person.

"You don't seem to be someone who complains a lot. I mean, you're not normally _____ _____ _____ are you?"

Your personality doesn't 'point in that direction'.

- He is naturally _____ to be shy in large crowds.
- Artistically _____ students often struggle with the rigid structure of traditional testing.
- Since I'm not mechanically _____, I usually call a professional to fix the sink.

- She is _____ to see the best in people, even when they let her down.
- I don't feel particularly _____ to help him again after he took all the credit last time.
- If the price is too high, customers simply won't be _____ to buy.

I will explore that word in a bit more detail later, after the quiz. Now let's move to…

Question 2

What idiom describes **someone who tends to be optimistic and focuses on the positive side of situations**?

Let's say you're talking to a friend and you want another way to say "You're an optimistic person" and you want to use a nice, common idiom.

It is quite a common expression that refers to a receptacle that, let's say, can contain 200ml of liquid but which contains 100ml of liquid.

Not: optimistic, positive

Sentence
She always stays positive — she's definitely a _____-_____-_____ type of person. She sees the _____ _____ _____.

Question 3

What verb means **to complain repeatedly (and annoyingly) about small or unimportant problems**?

What is the adjective to describe someone who does this a lot?

Imagine you are describing a person you know who complains a lot, but you don't want to just say "She complains a lot". You want another word for complain.

Not: whine, whinge, complain

- She's always moaning about everything: the weather, her job, having to wait for a train.
- Stop moaning about the weather — it's only a bit of rain.
- When the weather is bad it puts me in a bad mood and I can be a bit moany, which annoys my wife.

Question 4

What phrasal verb means **to reduce a list of possibilities until only a few remain**?

We had this in the "Engineer's Thumb" episode. In that story it referred to the shape of a character's face, which seemed to get thinner and thinner towards the bottom.

Imagine you are trying to choose a holiday destination. You've started with 10 places and you've reduced that number to just three places. You want another way to say "we've reduced it to 3 places"

Not: reduce

We had ten possible holiday destinations but we've _____ it _____ to three.

Question 5

What two adjectives describe **something you can see through clearly** - like a glass container, a window, something made of clear plastic.

You want to describe the fact that a container is made of a material that lets you see what is inside (like glass).

A t_____ container.

A s___-t_____ container.

We also use this word (and its noun form) to describe companies, governments etc - to mean that they are open, honest, clear and not hiding everything.

The bottle is made of _____ plastic so you can see how much water is left.

The company is committed to financial t_____. (noun)

Question 6

What adjective means **not see-through, something that blocks visibility**?

For example, you want to buy a container made of plastic which you can't see through - a container which you can't see inside.

The container is completely _____ so I can't see what's inside.

Question 7

What phrase describes **an urgent problem that needs immediate attention**?

Imagine you are talking about a serious problem that needs to be solved very soon.

This is a very _____ _____.

Not: urgent issue, serious problem, immediate worry, priority

Climate change is one of the most _____ _____ facing the world today.

Question 8

What phrase means **attached firmly so that it cannot move or come loose**?

Imagine you are on a plane and the captain is telling everyone to be sure that their seat belts are firmly attached.

Not: firmly attached, safely fixed, tightly connected

Please make sure your seatbelt is _____ _____ before the plane takes off.

Question 9

What phrasal verb means **to complete something you started or promised to do**?

It also has a rude meaning in which something awful happens in your underpants after you fart. We have dealt with this one before in the series about the word “through”.

He said he would help with the project but he never _____ _____ on his offer.

It was then that I realised I had _____ _____ and that I had no tissue paper and the public toilet was locked.

Question 10

What very informal, rude and vulgar expression, involving a swear word, means **to accidentally lose control of your bowels**?

Imagine you want to talk about having an accident in your trousers. Perhaps this was because you were sick, you farted and followed through, or because you laughed very hard.

It's also an expression that means you were extremely scared.

What is the past form of this expression?

He laughed so much he nearly _____ _____.
When I saw the bear coming towards me I nearly _____ _____.

Question 11

What noun refers to **loose men's underwear**?

Imagine you are going shopping for underwear and you need to ask someone in the shop where you can find this item. Underwear for men which is loose (not tight) and often has a couple of buttons on the front.

Excuse me, do you sell _____ _____?

What is the slang word for this?

He walked around the house wearing only his _____.

Question 12

What polite or humorous phrase refers to **someone's bottom, bum or buttocks**?

Not: arse (UK), ass (US), behind, bum, bottom

He slipped on the ice and landed on his _____ _____.

End of round 1. Time for a little breather.

ROUND 2

Question 13

What adjective describes very fine particles of water that sort of float in the air, a bit like a cloud. A very fine spray of water.

It is similar to fog or cloud, but a bit thinner and often on the ground or the surface of water in the morning?

A _____.

What is the adjective for this?

The shower created a _____ cloud of water in the bathroom.

Question 14

What verb means **to move sideways using small shaking movements as if you are moving up a bench which you are sitting on**?

Imagine you are sitting on a bench and you want someone to move up a bit.

“Can you just _____ over a bit” or you want to describe squeezing through a tight hole in a fence. “I had to _____ through the hole” or climbing up a drainpipe to get into a window “I just _____ up the drainpipe and climbed into the window.”

I had to _____ over to the corner to get away from this mist which sprayed out of the automatic toilet.

He had to _____ sideways through the narrow gap.

Question 15

What phrasal verb means **to appear suddenly or unexpectedly**? It's a very common phrasal verb, with a little word which we often use to describe quick sudden movements.

Imagine you are talking about an advertisement or a window which suddenly appears on your screen.

A strange message suddenly _____ _____ on my computer screen.

Question 16

What phrasal verb means **to have none left of something**?

This one is really common and surely very easy! Imagine you have to finish a meeting because there is no time left. What do you say, to describe that there is no time left. It's also for money, water, food and other resources.

OK everyone, it looks like we have _____ _____ _____ time, so I'm afraid we have to stop here.

Question 17

What expression means **to want or need something**? It includes the word *could*.

Imagine you really want a cup of coffee at this moment, but you don't want to say it too forcefully.

Not: I fancy a coffee, I'd love a coffee, I'm craving a coffee. Use the word *could*.

I **could do with** a cup of coffee right now.

Question 18

What phrase means **the main centre of attention in a place, object, or discussion**? The thing which people focus on.

Imagine you want to describe something which is the main focus of a place or thing, like perhaps the centre of a picture, or a place that most people look at, go to or think about.

It involves a variant on the word focus - the adjective form.

The statue in the town square is the _____ _____ of the whole area.

Question 19

What common animal-related idiom describes **the last problem in a series of other problems that finally causes someone to lose patience**?

Imagine you want to describe a moment when you completely lost your temper and got angry. A lot of annoying things had already happened, but you stayed in control, but then one final thing caused you to snap.

“Oh, that really is the _____ _____!”

This idiom involves an animal which has to carry a lot of things on its back, and putting one small final thing on the animal’s back causes it to break. It was the _____ _____ that broke the camel’s back.

When the train was delayed again it was the _____ _____. I just lost it.

Question 20

What illness do people get **after eating contaminated or badly cooked food**?

Imagine you ate some undercooked chicken and you got sick. You have stomach ache and you keep having to go to the toilet. You need to explain what the problem is.

I think I got _____ _____ after eating at that restaurant.

Question 21

What adjective describes **something concerned only with appearances and not deeper issues**?

Imagine you want to describe a person who is not very deep - someone who only cares about surface level things - like how attractive they are, what they look like, and they're not interested in deeper or more philosophical things.

I don't find her very genuine. I think she's quite a _____ person. She just cares about Instagram likes and that's it.

Judging someone only by their clothes is a very _____ attitude.

Question 22

What adjective refers to **the visual beauty or appearance of something**? It's often used when talking about art - the way things look beautiful, pleasing, attractive.

For example, items in a public toilet are not only chosen for their practical use, but also for their _____ appeal - they look quite nice.

They chose the furniture mainly for its _____ appeal.

Question 23

What phrase means **to be able to control when you go to the toilet**?

This refers to the part of your body which is responsible for controlling whether you do a poo or not. When you do a poo, this part “moves”.

Most adults normally have _____ _____ their b_____.

Question 24

What expression means **to accept or support an idea or plan**?

Imagine a boat or train - the boat is the idea, and when people support it they physically climb onto the boat.

They **get on board** the boat, or **get on board** *with* an idea.

It took a while but the whole team eventually _____ _____ _____ with the proposal.

End of round 2. Let’s take a quick breather. How are you getting on?

Now it’s time for the final round.

ROUND 3

Question 25

What slang adjective means **very unpleasant, disgusting or revolting**?

Imagine your friend has done something disgusting, like eating some food which they found on the floor. You might say “Oh my god I can’t believe you ate that. That is _____!”

That smell coming from the fridge is absolutely _____.

Question 26

What phrase means **to dispose of something by sending it away through the toilet system**?

You pull the chain or press a button and water fills the bowl and washes everything away. You _____ the toilet.

Someone _____ the paper towels _____ the toilet.

Question 27

What idiom means **to reveal gossip or negative information about someone**?

In this episode Charlie _____ the _____ about a famous English teaching YouTube star.

The journalist started _____ the _____ about several celebrities.

Question 28

What phrase means **to explain your argument or position clearly and systematically**?

Imagine a lawyer with a folder full of documents. They careful put all the documents down on the table and arrange them clearly.

The lawyer carefully _____ _____ his case to the jury.

Question 29

What expression refers to **behaviour that is not considered socially acceptable**?

Imagine you want to point out that certain behaviour is not what people normally do. For example, in our country, taking your shoes off when you are a guest at someone's house is not really normal so it might be

considered rude or strange. That isn't _____ _____ _____.

Interrupting people in meetings isn't really _____ _____ _____.

Question 30

What expression means **to have moved past something** or **to be better than it**?

Imagine you want to say that in society we have made progress and people no longer do certain things any more. For example, working a rigid 9-5 schedule at work is a thing of the past. We are **beyond** that now.

Wearing a suit and tie is not really necessary any more. I think as a culture we have moved _____ that now.

I thought society was _____ that kind of behaviour, but apparently people still do it.

Question 31

What phrase means **something is completely unacceptable**?

Imagine you have just witnessed someone being very rude to staff in a restaurant - abusing them, shouting at them and making outrageous demands - e.g. asking that their manager fires them for poor service.

You think it is completely unacceptable behaviour and you're shocked. You think that kind of thing is never ok. There is never a good reason for it.

There's absolutely _____ _____ _____ being rude to staff like that.

Question 32

What verb means **to deal with a situation successfully**, without getting upset, angry, confused?

Imagine you saw someone at work being criticised during a meeting and you thought that this person took the criticism well and dealt with it very professionally, without getting upset.

The expression sort of means that she used her hands, although it is used idiomatically just to say that someone controlled the situation well.

Not: dealt with

I think she _____ that situation very well.

Question 33

What expression means **to be mature enough not to react negatively to something**?

You might use it in a negative form to show you are disappointed with someone. Imagine someone disappointed you by acting badly, perhaps by being very unprofessional and taking some criticism very personally, and then getting upset and rudely insulting someone because she couldn't take the criticism.

I'm surprised and disappointed by her behaviour. I thought she was **better** than that. (the word *than* shows you that this is a comparative)

Try to be **better** than that and ignore the insult. Don't react.

Question 34

What informal (typically British) noun describes **something unnecessarily complicated** or **annoying to deal with**?

Imagine you are choosing a recipe to cook for an evening meal, and one recipe says you have to make your own pastry which involves mixing up the ingredients and rolling out the pastry yourself and it will take a lot of time, and will be tricky and inconvenient.

You say "Oh cooking that recipe is too much _____ for a weekday evening."

I spent an hour _____ _____ not doing anything in particular.

Question 35

What phrase describes **something being chosen purely because it is extremely convenient**?

To be honest it is an adjective which collocates with the word *convenience* and also some other words.

The adjective is an intensifier which means pure, total, or absolute.

For example, he chose the instant coffee just for the _____ convenience of it.

Not: absolute, total, complete, pure

We also use this with words like luck, determination and nonsense.

- I found my lost wedding ring in the middle of a crowded stadium by _____ luck.
- She managed to climb the final peak through _____ determination despite the freezing wind.
- The claim that the Earth is flat is nothing but _____ nonsense backed by zero evidence.

Vocabulary Quiz - Answers

Here are the answers to all the gaps in the vocabulary quiz.

1. To be that way inclined

- "You don't seem to be someone who complains a lot. I mean, you're not normally **that way inclined** are you?"
- He is naturally **inclined** to be shy in large crowds.
- Artistically **inclined** students often struggle with the rigid structure of traditional testing.
- Since I'm not mechanically **inclined**, I usually call a professional to fix the sink.
- She is **inclined** to see the best in people, even when they let her down.
- I don't feel particularly **inclined** to help him again after he took all the credit last time.
- If the price is too high, customers simply won't be **inclined** to buy.

2. Glass half full

- She always stays positive — she's definitely a **glass-half-full** type of person. She sees the **glass half full**.

3. Moan / moany

- She's always **moaning** about everything: the weather, her job, having to wait for a train.
- Stop **moaning** about the weather — it's only a bit of rain.
- When the weather is bad it puts me in a bad mood and I can be a bit **moany**, which annoys my wife.

4. Narrow something down

- We had ten possible holiday destinations but we've **narrowed** it **down** to three.

5. Transparent / see-through

- A **transparent** container.
- A **see-through** container.
- The bottle is made of **transparent** plastic so you can see how much water is left.
- The company is committed to financial **transparency**. (noun)

6. opaque

- The container is completely **opaque** so I can't see what's inside.

7. A pressing concern

- This is a very **pressing concern**.
- Climate change is one of the most **pressing concerns** facing the world today.

8. Securely fastened

- Please make sure your seatbelt is **securely fastened** before the plane takes off.

9. To follow through

- He said he would help with the project but he never **follow through** on his offer.
- It was then that I realised I had **followed through** and that I had no tissue paper and the public toilet was locked.

10. To shit yourself

- He laughed so much he nearly **shat himself**.

- When I saw the bear coming towards me I nearly **shat myself**.

11. Boxer shorts / boxers

- Excuse me, do you sell **boxer shorts**?
- He walked around the house wearing only his **boxers**.

12. Your rear end

He slipped on the ice and landed on his **rear end**.

13. Mist / misty

- A **mist**.
- The shower created a **misty** cloud of water in the bathroom.

14. Shimmy

- "Can you just **shimmy** over a bit" or you want to describe squeezing through a tight hole in a fence. "I had to **shimmy** through the hole" or climbing up a drainpipe to get into a window "I just **shimmied** up the drainpipe and climbed into the window."
- I had to **shimmy** over to the corner to get away from this mist which sprayed out of the automatic toilet.
- He had to **shimmy** sideways through the narrow gap.

15. To pop up

- A strange message suddenly **popped up** on my computer screen.

16. To run out of something

- OK everyone, it looks like we have **run out of** time, so I'm afraid we have to stop here.

17. I could do with + something

- I **could do with** a cup of coffee right now.

18. The focal point

- The statue in the town square is the **focal point** of the whole area.

19. The final straw

- "Oh, that really is the **final straw**!"
- This idiom involves an animal which has to carry a lot of things on its back, and putting one small final thing on the animal's back causes it to break. It was the **final straw** that broke the camel's back.
- When the train was delayed again it was the **final straw**. I just lost it.

20. To get food poisoning

- I think I got **food poisoning** after eating at that restaurant.

21. Superficial

- I don't find her very genuine. I think she's quite a **superficial** person. She just cares about Instagram likes and that's it.
- Judging someone only by their clothes is a very **superficial** attitude.

22. Aesthetic

- Items in a public toilet are not only chosen for their practical use, but also for their **aesthetic** appeal - they look quite nice.
- They chose the furniture mainly for its **aesthetic** appeal.

23. To have control over your bowels

- Most adults normally **have control over their bowels**.

24. To get on board with something

- They **get on board** the boat, or **get on board** *with* an idea.
- It took a while but the whole team eventually **got on board with** with the proposal.

25. Gross!

- "Oh my god I can't believe you ate that. That is **gross**!"
- That smell coming from the fridge is absolutely **gross**.

26. To flush (something down) the toilet

- You pull the chain or press a button and water fills the bowl and washes everything away. You **flush** the toilet.
- Someone **flushed** the paper towels **down** the toilet.

27. To dish the dirt on someone

- In this episode Charlie **dished** the **dirt** about a famous English teaching YouTube star.
- The journalist started **dished** the **dirt** about several celebrities.

28. To lay out your case

- The lawyer carefully **laid out his case** to the jury.

29. Not the done thing

- That isn't **the done thing**.
- Interrupting people in meetings isn't really **the done thing**.

30. To be beyond something

- Wearing a suit and tie is not really necessary any more. I think as a culture we have moved **beyond** that now.
- I thought society was **beyond** that kind of behaviour, but apparently people still do it.

31. There is no excuse for (doing) that

- There's absolutely **no excuse for** being rude to staff like that.

32. To handle something (well/badly)

- I think she **handled** that situation very well.

33. To be better than that

- I'm surprised and disappointed by her behaviour. I thought she was **better** than that. (the word *than* shows you that this is a comparative)
- Try to be **better** than that and ignore the insult. Don't react.

34. Faff / to faff about

- You say "Oh cooking that recipe is too much **faff** for a weekday evening."
- I spent an hour **faffing about** not doing anything in particular.

35. Sheer convenience

- He chose the instant coffee just for the **sheer** convenience of it.
- I found my lost wedding ring in the middle of a crowded stadium by **sheer** luck.
- She managed to climb the final peak through **sheer** determination despite the freezing wind.
- The claim that the Earth is flat is nothing but **sheer** nonsense backed by zero evidence.

2. Vocabulary Review – Detailed List

1. (to be) that way inclined

Original sentence

"*You're not normally that way inclined are you? You're more of a sort of the glass is half full type of person.*"

Base form

to be that way inclined

Part of speech

Adjective phrase

Definition

Used to describe someone who **naturally tends to behave or think in a particular way**. The noun form is ***inclination***. It's like a natural way of thinking, a talent, typical behaviour or a general position that you have on something - which defines how you like, feel about something or tend to behave.

Examples

- Some people enjoy extreme sports if they're **that way inclined**. (If they are the kinds of person who likes that kind of thing)
- You can stay for another drink if you're **that way inclined**. (if you want to)
- You can criticise the design if you're **that way inclined**. (If you are a critical person)

Common collocations

- if you're that way inclined
- people who are that way inclined
- for those that way inclined

Comments

Often used **slightly humorously or politely**, especially when referring to tastes, preferences, or personality traits.

Inclination vs preference - they're similar but different.

Examples

Inclination / to be inclined to do something

- **Natural Talent:** "Even as a child, she showed a strong **inclination** toward mathematics and logic."

- **A "Hunch" or Gut Feeling:** "My first **inclination** was to say no, but I decided to hear his full proposal first."
- **Behavioral Tendency:** "He has a worrying **inclination** to procrastinate when a project gets difficult."

Preference / to prefer to do/doing something

- **Taste/Liking:** "I have a strong **preference** for dark roast coffee over lighter blends."
- **Workplace Logistics:** "The manager asked the team for their **preference** regarding the new office layout."
- **Giving Priority:** "In the hiring process, **preference** will be given to candidates with previous experience in the field."
- **Comparative Choice:** "If I had to choose a seat, my **preference** would be the window so I can see the view."

Comparison: Using Both in One Context

Sometimes seeing them side-by-side makes the difference clearest:

> "Because of his artistic **inclination** (his natural talent/leanings), he has a clear **preference** (his specific choice) for working in design rather than accounting."
>
> "I have an **inclination** (a feeling) that it might rain, so my **preference** (my choice) is to move the party indoors."

Think of an **inclination** as a gentle pull or a starting point (or a direction in which you learn), while a **preference** is a more established choice or a liking.

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2. The glass is half full

Original sentence

"*You're more of a sort of the glass is half full type of person.*"

Base form

the glass is half full

Part of speech

Idiom / metaphorical expression

Definition

A way of describing **an optimistic person who focuses on the positive side of things**.

Examples

- She's definitely a **glass-half-full** kind of person.
- I try to see the **glass as half full**, even when things go wrong.
- He's always been a **glass-half-empty** type.

Common collocations

- glass-half-full attitude
- glass-half-empty person
- look at the glass as half full

Comments

Often contrasted with **"glass half empty"**, meaning pessimistic.

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3. Moany / to moan

Original sentence

"When it's raining and I feel like I've made poor choices to be stuck in the rain, then yeah, I could be a little bit moany."

Base form

moany / to moan

Part of speech

Adjective / verb

Definition

To complain frequently about small problems.

Examples

- Stop **moaning** about the weather.
- He's always **moaning** about his job.
- Don't be so **moany**, it's not that bad.

Common collocations

- moan about something
- moan endlessly
- constant moaning

Comments

Very common in **British English**.

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4. Narrow something down

Original sentence

"I've come up with quite a list. I've had to narrow them down."

Base form

to narrow something down

Part of speech

Phrasal verb

Definition

To **reduce the number of options** in order to choose more easily.

Examples

- We've **narrowed the list down** to three candidates.
- It took hours to **narrow down** the possibilities.
- Let's **narrow it down** to the most important issues.

Common collocations

- narrow down the options
- narrow down the suspects
- narrow down the list

Comments

Often used in **decision-making contexts**.

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5. Transparent

Original sentence

"*There's a toilet paper dispenser in there, but it is not transparent.*"

Part of speech

Adjective

Definition

Something you **can see through clearly**.

Examples

- The bottle is **transparent**.
- The company promised **transparent pricing**.
- The water was perfectly **transparent**.

Collocations

- transparent plastic
- transparent process
- transparent material

Comments

Also used metaphorically meaning **open or honest**.

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6. Pressing / pressing concern

Original sentence

"*There's a more pressing immediate concern when you've just done whatever you've done in the toilet.*"

Base form

pressing concern

Part of speech

Adjective + noun collocation

Definition

Something that is **urgent and requires immediate attention**.

Examples

- Climate change is a **pressing concern**.
- There are more **pressing issues** right now.
- Housing is a **pressing problem**.

Collocations

- pressing issue
- pressing need
- pressing matter

Comments

Common in **formal or serious discussion**.

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7. Opaque / see-through

Original sentence

"*So opaque toilet dispensers need to be banished.*"

Base form

opaque

Part of speech

Adjective

Definition

Not transparent; **you cannot see through it**.

Examples

- The glass is **opaque**.
- The explanation was **opaque and confusing**.
- Opaque containers hide the contents.

Collocations

- opaque surface
- opaque plastic
- opaque explanation

Comments

Opposite of **transparent**.

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8. Securely fastened

Original sentence

"*Being a public bathroom, you want to have it securely fastened.*"

Base form

to fasten

Part of speech

Verb

Definition

To **attach or close something firmly**.

Examples

- Make sure the seatbelt is **securely fastened**.
- The lid was **fastened tightly**.
- The door was **fastened shut**.

Collocations

- securely fastened
- fasten your seatbelt
- fasten the lid

Comments

Common safety instruction.

---

9. Follow through

Original sentence

"*Did you actually follow through?*"

Base form

to follow through

Part of speech

Phrasal verb

Definition

To **complete something you started**.

Examples

- He promised to help but didn't **follow through**.
- Always **follow through** on your commitments.
- She started the plan but never **followed through**.

Collocations

- follow through on a promise
- follow through with a plan
- follow through completely

Comments

Also used metaphorically in sports.

---

10. Shit yourself

Original sentence

"*Can you hurry up? I've just shat myself.*"

Base form

to shit yourself

Part of speech

Vulgar verb phrase

Definition

To accidentally **lose control of your bowels**.

Examples

- He nearly **shat himself** laughing.
- I thought I was going to **shit myself**.
- The rollercoaster made him **shit himself** with fear.

Collocations

- nearly shit yourself
- shit yourself laughing
- shit yourself with fear

Comments

Very **informal and crude language**.

---

11. Boxers

Original sentence

"*Because I had my boxers round my ankles.*"

Base form

boxer shorts / boxers

Part of speech

Noun

Definition

Loose **men's underwear**.

Examples

- He was walking around in his **boxers**.
- I need to buy new **boxer shorts**.
- He slept in his **boxers**.

Collocations

- boxer shorts
- wearing boxers
- cotton boxers

Comments

Short form **"boxers"** common in conversation.

---

12. Rear end

Original sentence

"*It starts shooting water up into my rear end.*"

Base form

rear end

Part of speech

Noun (euphemism)

Definition

A polite way to refer to **the buttocks**.

Examples

- He fell on his **rear end**.
- She slipped and landed on her **rear end**.
- He sat on his **rear end** all day.

Collocations

- fall on your rear end
- land on your rear end

Comments

Often used humorously.

---

13. Misty

Original sentence

"*It was misty. It was not directional enough.*"

Part of speech

Adjective

Definition

Something producing **a fine spray or mist**.

Examples

- The spray created a **misty** cloud.
- The bathroom was **misty** with steam.
- The fountain produced a **misty** effect.

Collocations

- misty spray
- misty atmosphere
- misty water

---

14. Shimmy over

Original sentence

"*I shimmy over to the corner.*"

Base form

to shimmy

Part of speech

Verb

Definition

To **move sideways in small shaking movements**.

Examples

- He **shimmied** through the narrow gap.
- She **shimmied** along the wall.
- The dancer **shimmied** across the stage.

Collocations

- shimmy along
- shimmy through
- shimmy sideways

---

15. Pop up

Original sentence

"*These little pop-up sprinklers come from each corner.*"

Base form

to pop up

Part of speech

Phrasal verb

Definition

To **appear suddenly**.

Examples

- A problem **popped up**.
- An ad **popped up** on my screen.
- He **popped up** unexpectedly.

Collocations

- suddenly pop up
- pop up on screen
- problems pop up

---

16. Run out

Original sentence

"*I use a few and then it runs out.*"

Base form

to run out

Part of speech

Phrasal verb

Definition

To **have none left**.

Examples

- We **ran out of milk**.
- The battery **ran out**.
- Time **ran out**.

Collocations

- run out of time
- run out of money
- run out of fuel

---

17. I could do with

Original sentence

"I could do with 90% more than what I've just used."

Base form

could do with

Part of speech

Modal phrase

Definition

To **want or need something**.

Examples

- I **could do with** a coffee.
- We **could do with** some help.
- I **could do with** a holiday.

Collocations

- could do with a break
- could do with some help

Comments

Very common in **British English**.

---

18. Focal point / faecal point

Original sentence

"*There's a whole other range of things that could have been the focal point or faecal point maybe.*"

Base form

focal point

Part of speech

Noun

Definition

The **main point of attention**.

Examples

- The statue is the **focal point** of the square.
- The debate became the **focal point** of the meeting.
- The fireplace is the **focal point** of the room.

Collocations

- main focal point
- visual focal point

Comments

“Faecal point” is a **joke/pun**.

---

19. Final straw

Original sentence

"*It seems to be just like the final straw maybe.*"

Base form

the final straw

Part of speech

Idiom

Definition

The **last problem that makes a situation unbearable**.

Examples

- That complaint was the **final straw**.
- Losing my keys was the **final straw**.
- The delay was the **final straw**.

Collocations

- the final straw for someone

Comments

From **“the straw that broke the camel’s back.”**

---

20. Food poisoning

Original sentence

"*The main problem should be food poisoning.*"

Part of speech

Noun

Definition

Illness caused by **eating contaminated food**.

Examples

- I got **food poisoning** from seafood.
- Several customers reported **food poisoning**.
- He was hospitalised with **food poisoning**.

Collocations

- severe food poisoning
- suspected food poisoning

---

21. Superficial

Original sentence

"*I'm very surprised at how superficial you're being.*"

Part of speech

Adjective

Definition

Concerned with **appearance rather than deeper issues**.

Examples

- Their friendship felt **superficial**.
- That's a very **superficial** judgement.
- Social media can encourage **superficial thinking**.

Collocations

- superficial level
- superficial judgement

---

22. Aesthetic

Original sentence

"*This particular element of your life that needs to be aesthetic.*"

Part of speech

Adjective

Definition

Relating to **appearance or beauty**.

Examples

- The design is very **aesthetic**.
- They focused on the **aesthetic appeal**.
- The building has strong **aesthetic value**.

Collocations

- aesthetic appeal
- aesthetic design

---

23. Have control over your bowels

Original sentence

"*Well you know I have control over my bowels.*"

Base form

to have control over your bowels

Part of speech

Verb phrase

Definition

To be able to **control when you defecate**.

Examples

- He struggled to **control his bowels**.
- Patients sometimes lose **bowel control**.
- She regained **control of her bowels**.

Collocations

- bowel control
- lose control of your bowels

---

24. Get on board with something

Original sentence

"*They had a bidet and I got on board with that.*"

Base form

to get on board with something

Part of speech

Phrasal verb

Definition

To **accept or support an idea**.

Examples

- The team quickly **got on board with the plan**.
- Investors are starting to **get on board**.
- Everyone eventually **got on board with the changes**.

Collocations

- get on board with the idea
- get everyone on board

---

25. Gross

Original sentence

"*It's gross to use toilet paper.*"

Part of speech

Adjective

Definition

Very **disgusting or unpleasant**.

Examples

- That smell is **gross**.
- The food looked **gross**.
- That's **gross behaviour**.

Collocations

- really gross
- gross smell
- gross habit

---

26. Flush something down the toilet

Original sentence

"*Not flushing all that paper down the toilet.*"

Base form

to flush something down the toilet

Part of speech

Verb phrase

Definition

To dispose of something by sending it through the toilet system.

Examples

- He **flushed the tissue down the toilet**.
- Someone **flushed wipes down the toilet**.
- Don't **flush plastic down the toilet**.

Collocations

- flush it away
- flush down the toilet

Comments

Also used metaphorically meaning **to waste something**.

---

27. Dish the dirt on someone

Original sentence

"*Dishing the dirt on a YouTuber.*"

Base form

to dish the dirt

Part of speech

Idiom / phrasal verb

Definition

To reveal **gossip or negative information about someone**.

Examples

- He loves **dishing the dirt** on celebrities.
- She started **dishing the dirt** about her ex.
- Journalists tried to **dish the dirt**.

Collocations

- dish the dirt on someone
- gossip and dish the dirt

---

28. Lay out your case

Original sentence

"*Would you like to lay out your case against instant coffee?*"

Base form

to lay out your case

Part of speech

Verb phrase

Definition

To **explain your arguments clearly and systematically**.

Examples

- The lawyer **laid out the case** for the defence.
- He **laid out his argument** clearly.
- Let me **lay out the facts**.

Collocations

- lay out your argument
- lay out the evidence

---

29. It's not the done thing

Original sentence

"*It's not the done thing anymore.*"

Base form

the done thing

Part of speech

Idiom

Definition

Something that is **socially acceptable or appropriate**.

Examples

- Wearing hats indoors isn't **the done thing**.

- It's not **the done thing** to interrupt.
- That used to be **the done thing**.

Collocations

- simply not the done thing

---

30. Beyond something

Original sentence

"We're beyond that. We're better than that."

Base form

to be beyond something

Part of speech

Adjective phrase

Definition

To have **moved past something or improved beyond it**.

Examples

- Society should be **beyond racism**.
- I'm **beyond caring** now.
- We're **beyond that stage**.

Collocations

- beyond repair

- beyond help
- beyond that

---

31. There's no excuse for something

Original sentence

"*There's no excuse for instant coffee anymore.*"

Base form

there is no excuse for

Part of speech

Phrase

Definition

A way of saying something is **unacceptable or unjustifiable**.

Examples

- There's **no excuse for violence**.
- There's **no excuse for being late**.
- There's **no excuse for bad service**.

Collocations

- absolutely no excuse
- no excuse whatsoever

---

32. Handle something

Original sentence

"*I think she can handle this feedback.*"

Base form

to handle

Part of speech

Verb

Definition

To **deal with something successfully**.

Examples

- She handled the situation well.
- Can you handle the pressure?
- He couldn't handle the criticism.

Collocations

- handle criticism
- handle pressure
- handle a situation

---

33. Bigger than something

Original sentence

"*She's bigger than this.*"

Base form

to be bigger than something

Part of speech

Idiom

Definition

To be **emotionally mature enough not to react negatively**.

Examples

- Be **bigger than that**.
- Try to be **bigger than the argument**.
- She was **bigger than the insult**.

Collocations

- be the bigger person

---

34. Faff

Original sentence

"*It's just a lot of faff.*"

Part of speech

Noun (informal)

Definition

Something that is **unnecessarily complicated or annoying to deal with**.

Examples

- Filling in forms is such a **faff**.
- It's too much **faff** to cook tonight.
- That system is a real **faff**.

Collocations

- too much faff
- unnecessary faff

Comments

Very **British informal vocabulary**.

---

35. Sheer convenience

Original sentence

"*The sheer convenience of it wins.*"

Base form

sheer

Part of speech

Adjective intensifier

Definition

Used to emphasise **how strong or complete something is**.

Examples

- It was **sheer luck**.
- He won through **sheer determination**.
- She succeeded by **sheer effort**.

Collocations

- sheer luck
- sheer determination
- sheer convenience

• Vocabulary Practice Exercises

Room 101 Vocabulary Review. Parts 1-4 are not too difficult, but this is an important step to help you quickly check and review what you have learned so far.

Part 1 — Match the Meaning

Match the expressions (A–R) to their meanings (1–18).

Expressions

A. that way inclined	J. run out
B. glass half full	K. pop up
C. moan	L. could do with

D. narrow something down	M. focal point
E. transparent	N. final straw
F. pressing concern	O. superficial
G. opaque	P. aesthetic
H. securely fastened	Q. gross
I. follow through	R. faff

Meanings

1. When something appears suddenly
2. Very disgusting
3. Want or need something
4. To complain repeatedly
5. Something urgent that needs attention
6. The centre of attention
7. Something you can see through
8. Not see-through
9. Something unnecessarily complicated
10. Someone optimistic
11. Concerned only with appearances
12. The last problem that makes someone lose patience
13. To complete something you started
14. Attached firmly
15. To reduce a list of options
16. Having no more left
17. Relating to beauty or appearance
18. Naturally interested in something

Part 2 — Complete the Sentences

Fill the gaps using the correct vocabulary item.

1. Stop m_____ about the weather — it's only a bit of rain.
2. We had ten possible restaurants but we finally n_____ it d_____ to three.
3. Make sure the lid is s_____ f_____ before putting it in your bag.
4. A strange error message suddenly p_____ u_____ on my screen.
5. I c_____ d_____ w_____ a cup of coffee right now.
6. The statue in the square is the f_____ p_____ of the whole area.
7. When the computer crashed for the third time, it was the l_____ s_____.
8. That smell coming from the fridge is absolutely g_____.
9. I thought society was b_____ that kind of behaviour.
10. Filling out all these forms is such a f_____.

Part 3 — Choose the Correct Expression

Choose the best expression to complete the sentence.

1. We've _____ milk so someone needs to go to the shop.
   (a) popped up
   (b) run out of
   (c) followed through

2. The politician promised reform but never _____ on the plan.
   (a) followed through
   (b) narrowed down
   (c) popped up

3. The bottle is _____ so you can see how much water is inside.
   (a) opaque

(b) transparent
(c) gross

4. I'm surprised you're complaining — you're usually more of a _____ type of person.
   (a) faff
   (b) glass half full
   (c) focal point

5. That behaviour isn't really _____ anymore.
   (a) the done thing
   (b) the final straw
   (c) sheer convenience

Part 4 — Word Formation / Expression Recall

Complete the expressions.

1. dish the _____
2. lay out your _____
3. get on _____ with something
4. have control over your _____
5. flush something down the _____

Answer Key Parts 1-4

Part 1

A – 18	G – 8	M – 6
B – 10	H – 14	N – 12
C – 4	I – 13	O – 11
D – 15	J – 16	P – 17
E – 7	K – 1	Q – 2
F – 5	L – 3	R – 9

Part 2

1. moaning / moan
2. narrowed it down
3. securely fastened
4. popped up
5. could do with
6. focal point
7. final straw
8. gross
9. beyond
10. faff

Part 3

1. run out of
2. followed through
3. transparent
4. glass half full
5. the done thing

Part 4

1. dirt
2. case
3. board
4. bowels
5. toilet

Part 5: Vocabulary Story Exercise

The Worst Café Toilet in Paris

Fill in the numbered gaps in this story with the correct vocabulary expressions.

Last weekend I went to visit a small café run by a friend of mine. Now, normally I'm quite an optimistic person. In fact, you could say I'm more of a **(1)** _____ _____ _____ _____ type of person. I usually try to see the positive side of things — I tend to think the **(2)** _____ _____ _____ _____.

But this particular day pushed my optimism to its limits.

I had gone there partly to work on a podcast episode called Room 101. I was preparing a list of things that annoy me, and I'd come up with quite a long list. Eventually I had to **(3)** _____ _____ _____ to just a few items.

My first complaint concerned public toilets — specifically toilet paper dispensers. This was inspired by the actual toilet in the cafe.

In my opinion toilet paper dispensers should be **(4)** _____, so you can easily see how much paper is left. Unfortunately, the one in this café was completely **(5)** _____. You couldn't see anything inside it.

And of course, the inevitable happened.

At the worst possible moment, just when I needed it the most, the toilet paper **(6)** _____ _____.

Now, in that situation the design of the dispenser becomes a very **(7)** _____ _____.

I tried to open the dispenser to get more paper, but it was **(8)** _____ _____ to the wall and impossible to move.

Meanwhile, I started having a horrible thought.

"What if I actually **(9)** _____ _____?"

Let me describe the situation.

My **(10)** _____ were around my ankles and my poor **(11)** _____ _____ was dangerously exposed.

Suddenly the automatic cleaning system activated and produced a strange **(12)** _____ spray of water.

Naturally I tried to **(13)** _____ sideways away from it.

But then something even worse happened.

Two small sprinklers suddenly **(14)** _____ _____ from the floor, soaking my trousers.

At this point I realised that I had completely **(15)** _____ _____ of toilet paper.

I looked at the empty dispenser and thought,

"I really **(16)** _____ _____ _____ a lot more paper than this, for several reasons."

Ironically, the café owner later discovered that several customers had actually suffered **(18)** _____ _____ from the food.

But instead of worrying about that, he seemed more concerned with completely **(19)** _____ things — like whether the bathroom looked nice.

He said the interior design needed to be more **(20)** _____.

Personally I think if you don't **(21)** _____ _____ _____ **your** _____, the design of the bathroom isn't quite as important as the amount of toilet paper available.

Still, I must admit that later, after trying a proper bidet, I did eventually **(22)** _____ _____ _____ the idea of water spraying in a toilet.

Sorry, this story is a bit **(23)** _____ isn't it? I hope you don't mind all the details.

Anyway, later that day someone started **(24)** _____ _____ _____ about a famous YouTuber who shockingly drinks cheap instant coffee.

They asked me to **(25)** _____ _____ **my** _____ against instant coffee, which I happily did.

After all, these days there's really **(26)** _____ _____ _____ it. Good coffee is very easy to make.

Someone then said criticising a YouTuber wasn't **(27)** _____ _____ _____, but I think she can **(28)** _____ it. She's definitely **(29)** _____ than that.

Although I must admit, making proper coffee involves quite a lot of **(30)** _____. Grinding beans, weighing them, cleaning the machine… It's a pain in the neck really, especially if you're busy.

Sometimes the **(31)** _____ _____ of instant coffee wins.

Anyway, after everything that happened that day, the broken toilet dispenser truly became the **(32)** _____ _____.

You'll probably agree that it was all a bit too much, unless, of course, you're **(33) i**_____ to enjoy this kind of story.

And if you are, then congratulations — you've just survived the most ridiculous vocabulary lesson I've ever created.

Answer Key - Part 5

1. glass half full 2. glass half full 3. narrow them down 4. transparent 5. opaque 6. ran out 7. pressing concern 8. securely fastened 9. shit myself (alternatively: follow through) 10. boxers 11. rear end	12. misty 13. shimmy 14. popped up 15. run out 16. could do with 17. 18. food poisoning 19. superficial 20. aesthetic 21. have control over your bowels 22. get on board with 23. gross	24. dishing the dirt 25. lay out my case 26. no excuse for 27. the done thing 28. handle 29. bigger 30. faff 31. sheer convenience 32. final straw 33. that way inclined

Discussion Questions for Speaking Practice – Room 101 Vocabulary

Personality & Attitude

1. Would you say you are someone who sees **the glass as half full** or half empty? Can you give an example from your life?
2. Are you someone who complains a lot, or do you try not to **moan**? What things make you moan the most?
3. Do you think you are **that way inclined** to worry about small details, or are you more relaxed about things?

Decision-Making & Priorities

4. When you have too many options (restaurants, films, holidays), how do you usually **narrow things down**?
5. What is the most **pressing concern** in your life right now?

6. What do you think should be the **focal point** of someone's life — career, family, happiness, something else?

Everyday Problems

7. Tell us about a time when something suddenly **popped up** and ruined your plans.
8. What things in your life have you recently **run out of**?
9. What do you **could do with** right now? A holiday? More sleep? A coffee?

Complaining & Frustration

10. What small problem in daily life would be your **final straw** if it happened repeatedly?
11. Do you ever feel people complain about **superficial** things instead of important ones? Can you give an example?
12. What things do people sometimes find **gross** but you don't mind?

Design & Objects

13. Do you prefer things to be **transparent** so you can see inside them (like containers or machines)?
14. Can you think of situations where it's better for something to be **opaque**?
15. When travelling, what things do you always make sure are **securely fastened**?
16. What place in your home has the strongest **aesthetic** appeal?

Behaviour & Social Norms

17. What things were once normal but are no longer **the done thing**?
18. Are there habits or behaviours that you think society should be **beyond** by now?

19. Do you think there is **no excuse for** certain behaviours? Which ones?

Handling Problems

20. When someone criticises you, do you usually **handle** it well?
21. When someone insults you, are you usually able to be **bigger than that**, or do you react?

Gossip & Arguments

22. Do you enjoy hearing gossip? Do your friends ever **dish the dirt** about people they know?
23. If you strongly disagree with something, how do you **lay out your case**?

Convenience & Effort

24. What things do you do because of **sheer convenience**, even if they are not the best option?
25. What tasks in everyday life feel like too much **faff**?

Preferences & Change

26. Was there something you didn't like at first but eventually **got on board with**?
27. What technologies or trends did people resist at first but later accept?

Funny / Storytelling Questions

28. Have you ever been in a situation where you thought you might **shit yourself** with fear or laughter?
29. Have you ever had an embarrassing situation involving your **boxers** or clothes?
30. Have you ever slipped and landed on your **rear end**?
31. Have you ever had to **shimmy** through a small space?

Hypothetical / Opinion Questions

32. If you were designing a bathroom, what would be the most important things? Would **aesthetics** matter, or would practicality be the **focal point**?
33. What small inconvenience in public places annoys you the most?